

Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 Subject of the Dissertation

Vincent d'Indy's contributions to musical composition and education have established him as a pivotal figure in late nineteenth and early twentieth-century French music. While d'Indy presents himself as Franck's spokesperson, his theory exhibits a high degree of individuality and freely appropriates Franck's ideas. Jann Pasler endows, "his [d'Indy's] conception of Franckism as an oppositional current in French music, a parallel to Wagnerism, eventually fashioned him as the disciple of Franck by helping a group identity coalesce and a lineage begin" [Pasler, 2008]. At the Schola Cantorum, which he helped establish, his educational philosophy promoted an integrated and organic approach to musical training, influencing the curricular frameworks of the study of music history, performance and composition. This educational philosophy extended to his theoretical works, notably seen in his *Cours de composition musicale*, where he articulates a structured, yet flexible approach to musical form [d'Indy, 1903] [d'Indy, 1909] [d'Indy, 1933] [d'Indy, 1950].

This research project aims to test d'Indy's formal theories by applying them to the analysis of Beethoven's instrumental works. It examines key elements of d'Indy's approach, such as the division of a piece of music into units of varying lengths, his articulation techniques, and his description of formal functions. By clarifying d'Indy's system in verbalizing what remains implicit in his definitions,



and by adopting a critical view to his analytical system, this study seeks to offer new insights into his methodological consistency.

1.2 Literature Review

Campos and Donin describe d'Indy as "the first figure in France to adopt new practice," moving between "musical writing and writing about music," while promoting performers and standards consistent with his theoretical framework. They note that "d'Indy's poetics, which implies the systematic control by the author over composition, performance, listening, teaching, and commentary, would become more radical as the musician's life progressed." ¹

This portrayal of d'Indy as a pioneering figure is further complemented by Ellis, who suggests that d'Indy was "perhaps the first to write a history of musical style and genre that is more dependent on 'resonances' than on the establishment or presentation of music-historical 'facts'" [Ellis, 2006, p. 111]. According to Ellis, d'Indy constructs a historiographical lineage in his *Cours de composition*, emphasizing a compositional "resonance" between figures like Palestrina, Bach, and Beethoven, linking them to Wagner's ideals of "interior expression over external effect," but omits César Franck, with whom he had a uniquely influential mentor-student relationship. Furthermore, Ellis highlights how d'Indy's *Cours* reflects his ideological commitment to a moralized view of music history, where composers are judged according to their alignment with Wagnerian principles, underscoring the "parallel

¹Campos and Donin originally wrote, "En France, Vincent d'Indy est la première figure à adopter cette nouvelle pratique : compositeur de premier plan, auteur de textes théoriques [...], il a lui-même sans cesse opéré le va-et-vient entre écriture musicale et écriture sur la musique, en même temps qu'il promouvait des interprètes et des standards d'interprétation cohérents avec ces écritures. La poétique d'indyste, qui suppose le contrôle systématique par l'auteur de la composition, de l'exécution, de l'écoute, de l'enseignement et du commentaire, ira en se radicalisant au cours de la vie du musicien et connaîtra tout au long du siècle, outre ses avatars français, de nombreux équivalents dans d'autres courants esthétiques européens dont une étude transversale est à espérer." [Donin and Campos, 2006, pp. 155-6]

struggles between the good and the bad, the pure and the impure" [Ellis, 2006, p. 112]. This idealistic framework suggests a vision of music as a moral and aesthetic force, moving toward a higher, almost spiritual purpose.

However, the idealism of d'Indy's approach was not mere intellectual fantasies, free from connections to the empirical world. In her critical examination, "Archéologue malgré lui: Vincent d'Indy et les usages de l'histoire," Annegret Fauser discovered that "the positivist training of d'Indy, studying law in the tradition of Auguste Comte, adds a systematic current to the historical edifice that is reflected in the very construction of the *Cours de composition musicale*."² This foundation is reflected not only in its historical methodology (chronology, biographical elements) but also in d'Indy's application of empirical methods to music analysis, particularly his formative analysis of Beethoven's works.

D'Indy's positivist background shaped his preference for structure and formal rigor over subjective expression. Suchowiejko points out that d'Indy was critical of what he perceived as the unrestrained subjectivity of Romantic composers, such as Schubert and Chopin, whom he criticized for their "lack of formal conscience" and whose works, he believed, lacked the structural discipline he championed. Central to d'Indy's teaching was the "dogme de la forme"—the belief that form was not merely a tool but a guiding principle in composition [Suchowiejko, 2006, p. 103]. Suchowiejko notes that this rejection of subjectivity in favor of formalism is central to d'Indy's pedagogical approach, where students were taught to prioritize form as the foundation of musical composition.

D'Indy's commitment to formalism naturally extended into his structuralist and functionalist approach, where the roles of harmonic, melodic, and rhythmic elements were analyzed in relation to the whole. According to Campos' 2013 article, d'Indy's theory has been original by applying the concept of tonality across all musical phenomena, defining tonality in a way that encompasses rhythm, melody, and harmony,

²Fauser originally wrote, "la formation positiviste de d'Indy, étudiant en droit dans la tradition d'Auguste Comte, ajoute un courant systématique à l'édifice historique qui se reflète dans la construction même du *Cours de composition musicale*"[Fauser, 2006, p.124].

unlike theories who considered these elements separately.³ By integrating Rameau's harmonic theories with Riemann's functionalism, d'Indy sought to create a cohesive system linking these elements through their tonal functions.⁴

Historical knowledge is seen not as objective or neutral, but as constructed by specific discourses and power relations. [De Médicis](#) challenges d'Indy's tendency to centralize Beethoven's influence through his historiographical narratives, particularly in his studies of César Franck, thereby addressing the gap left by Ellis. Despite d'Indy's assertion that "Franck's cyclic writing is rooted directly in the works of Beethoven's third period, independently from any other European composer" [de Médicis, 2024, p. 75], de Médicis advocates for a more pluralistic and decentralized perspective, comparing Franck's work to those of other composers, including Brahms and Liszt. By questioning the stability and objectivity of d'Indy's claims, de Médicis argues that these claims do not align with Franck's actual intentions, nor with what can be concluded through a critical evaluation of the facts.



The existing reviews suggest a strong focus on d'Indy's theoretical and pedagogical approaches, his historical narratives, and his systematic control over musical processes. Yet, several areas appear underexplored or insufficiently critiqued.

The assessments of music theory centering on Beethoven's Sonata form within the scope of *Cours de composition musicale* remain underexplored. While Campos illustrated this functionalist approach through d'Indy's analysis of Beethoven's

³Campos wrote, "Son originalité est d'appliquer la notion à 'l'ensemble des phénomènes musicaux', en décrétant un terme de comparaison unique que d'Indy baptise du nom de tonique[...]. La tonalité concerne donc aussi bien le rythme et la mélodie que l'harmonie" [Campos, 2013, pp. 75-7].

⁴Campos wrote, "En posant que le principe de la tonalité permet 'de rattacher, à l'aide de la tonalité harmonique la résonance harmonique et la tonique,' d'Indy mêle habilement une version modernisée de la théorie ramiste et un fonctionnalisme inspiré des thèses de Riemann" [Campos, 2013, p. 77].

"Hammerklavier" and "Lebewohl" Sonatas, the discussion on d'Indy's analytical method tends to be descriptive, focusing mainly on reporting d'Indy's assertions rather than critically engaging with the music theory itself [Campos, 2013, pp. 79-84]. This leaves potentials for exploration and original critique, particularly in examining the internal coherence of d'Indy's theoretical framework and in assessing whether d'Indy's theories consistently hold up when applied to his given musical examples.

In order for criticism to be effective, it is necessary to introduce materials beyond d'Indy's text. De Médicis engaged only with d'Indy's claims on stylistic lineage and with the author's theory of cyclic form (as other scholars before de Médicis). But nobody has engaged in the other aspects (and more basic elements) of d'Indy's theory of form. However, bringing in a contemporary theory to confront d'Indy's—using the same examples to expose discrepancies—offers a contrasting way to reevaluate the theory. Furthermore, while de Médicis successfully deconstructs some of d'Indy's claims, some of them remain open-ended questions. A reconstruction of d'Indy's theory in light of contemporary insights could be revealing.

1.3 Methodology

1.3.1 Examination of Internal Coherence

A structured analysis of d'Indy's theoretical terminology and values is conducted to establish clarity and highlight his core ideas. This involves:

1. Defining key terms and concepts by situating them within a structured hierarchy, showing their interrelationships to build a foundational understanding of d'Indy's analytical vocabulary.
2. Engaging with d'Indy's analyses to assess the clarity and coherence of his theoretical assertions. This includes identifying any contradictions or ambiguous points within his analyses and providing explanations or justifications where needed to clarify his theoretical framework.

3. Identifying underlying values by examining how his theoretical constructs prioritize elements, drawing parallels to a few other music theorists, and using these comparisons to provide a more grounded perspective on d'Indy's theoretical stance.

1.3.2 Comparative Analysis with Contemporary Theories

A comparative analysis is conducted between d'Indy's theoretical interpretations and those posited by modern theorists, such as William Caplin, in their analyses of Beethoven's compositions. This involves:

1. Identifying works where the two scholars have provided analyses of multiple passages, with a particular focus on shared analyses within Beethoven's works to establish a common foundation for comparison.
2. Identifying discrepancies in their respective analyses within the exposition section, assessing the analytical limitations of d'Indy's work, and speculating on possible reasons for these limitations through comparison.
3. Examining the same passages analyzed by both scholars, referring back to previously developed concepts, drawing parallels, and using Caplin's more modern theory to address ambiguities in d'Indy's analyses, to explore whether there is a modern equivalent for d'Indy's expressions.

1.4 Outline

Chapter 2 introduces the necessary analytical frameworks for conducting comparative analyses, focusing primarily on Vincent d'Indy's theoretical approaches and key concepts centering around the exposition section of Beethoven's Sonata form, which are essential for understanding the analyses that follow, as well as his core values, which resonate with broader theoretical foundations in his contemporary.

This chapter serves as a foundational prerequisite by establishing a detailed understanding of d'Indy's views. Additionally, it provides a brief overview of William Caplin's analytical framework, offering readers the necessary context to appreciate the comparative aspects discussed later.

Chapter 3 delves into contrasting the exposition sections of three sonata movements, reinforcing the theoretical frameworks established in the previous chapter. It begins by contrasting the interpretations of Beethoven's 5th Symphony, highlighting differences in thematic organization and refining Caplinian analysis with insights drawn from d'Indy's approach.

As the analysis progresses, the discussion of subsequent repertoire builds upon the theoretical ideas articulated in the initial analysis. A similar setup is employed for the discussion of the "Hammerklavier" Sonata in Chapter 4, beginning with the discussion of the generation of the main theme, that serves as a second example enhancing the consistency of the application of d'Indy's theory. This section then also tackles discrepancies in labeling the transition and subordinate theme.

The final chapter, Chapter 5 synthesizes the findings from the comparative analysis, explaining the reasons behind the discrepancies observed between the theories of d'Indy and Caplin. It critiques the methodologies and makes general statements about the conditions that may render one theoretical approach more effective than another. This chapter aims to provide a reflective critique that could influence future theoretical developments in music analysis.